Earthquake Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/what-to-do-during-an-earthquake/, which lists its sources. Updated November 12, 2026.

What to do during the shaking

1. **Drop** to your hands and knees before the shaking knocks you down.
2. **Cover** your head and neck under a sturdy table or desk. If there's none nearby, crawl next to an interior wall, away from windows, and cover your head and neck with your arms.
3. **Hold on** to the table, or to your head and neck, until the shaking stops. Be ready to move with the table.

In bed

Stay there. Cover your head and neck with a pillow.

Outdoors

Drop, then move to open space away from buildings, power lines and trees.

Driving

Stop somewhere clear of buildings, trees, overpasses and wires, and stay in the car.

Wheelchair or walker

Lock the wheels, stay seated, bend over and protect your head and neck.

Near the coast

Drop, cover and hold on, then go to high ground or inland as soon as the shaking stops. Don't wait for a warning.

What to do after an earthquake

- Pause, look for hazards, then move. Put on sturdy shoes before walking on broken glass.

- Expect aftershocks. Drop, cover and hold on each time.
- Check yourself and others for injuries.
- If the building is damaged, leave carefully and watch for falling hazards outside.
- If you smell gas or hear hissing, don't use matches, lighters, appliances or light switches. Get out and call 911 from outside, then your gas company.
- Use flashlights, not candles.
- If you're trapped, cover your mouth and nose, and signal by blowing a whistle or tapping on a pipe or wall rather than shouting.
- Text family that you're safe; texts get through more easily than calls.

Earthquake checklist

- [ ] Practice drop, cover and hold on with everyone at home
- [ ] Strap TVs, bookcases, water heaters and tall furniture to the wall
- [ ] Sturdy shoes, a flashlight and a whistle by each bed
- [ ] Know how to shut off your gas, water and electricity
- [ ] Water: 1 gallon per person per day, 2 weeks if you can
- [ ] Food that needs no cooking, and a manual can opener
- [ ] A first-aid kit and a month of medicines
- [ ] Dust masks and work gloves
- [ ] A battery or hand-crank radio and power banks
- [ ] A go bag with 3 days of supplies

- [ ] Copies of important documents
- [ ] Check whether your insurance covers earthquakes

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.